



GERMANY



THE FEDERAL REPUBLIC of Germany lies at the heart of Europe, bounded by nine other nations and the Baltic and North Seas. Since the country was reunified in 1990, it is, more than ever, a link between east and west for both trade and culture. Germany is one of the world's wealthiest nations and Europe's leading industrial power. It was a founder member of the European Union and plays a key role in international affairs. Germany has the second largest population in Europe after Russia.

Physical features

Germany has a varied landscape. It includes lakes, heaths, and islands in the north, fertile pastures and great forests in the centre and southwest, and great mountains, such as the Bavarian Alps, in the south.



GERMANY FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Berlin
AREA	356,910 sq km (137,800 sq miles)
POPULATION	82,200,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	German
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Euro
LIFE EXPECTANCY	78 years
PEOPLE PER DOCTOR	286
GOVERNMENT	Multi-party democracy
ADULT LITERACY	99%

River Rhine

The Rhine is one of Europe's most important rivers. It rises in the Swiss Alps and flows into the North Sea at Rotterdam in the Netherlands. The total length is about 1,320 km (820 miles), nearly half of which is in Germany. Long barges regularly carry freight such as coal, grain, and timber. Many tourists visit the southern part of the Rhine to see the scenery, vineyards, and castles that flank its sides.

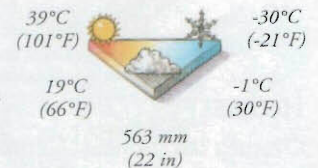
Black Forest

Germany's Black Forest lies in the southwest of the country. The name comes from the dark conifers that clothe its mountain slopes and provide timber for the traditional wooden houses. Tourists flock to the region, attracted by the beauty of the scenery, spa resorts, such as Baden-Baden, and Lake Constance, which lies nearby.



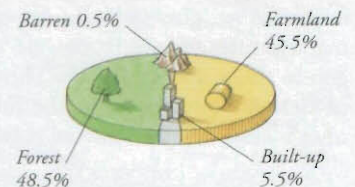
Climate

Northern and central Germany have mild summers, and cool, damp winters. The southern and mountainous areas, such as the Harz Mountains, the Black Forest, and Bavaria, have much hotter summers and cold winters with heavy snow.



Land use

Germany has relatively few natural resources, and forest covers almost half the country. Most of the land is fertile and is used for growing crops or raising animals.



Berlin

The Brandenburg Gate in Berlin symbolizes the reunification of Germany in 1990 when the Berlin Wall, built after World War II (1939-45) to separate East and West, was demolished. Always a thriving centre of art and culture, there are plans to rebuild this grand capital, Germany's largest city.



Brandenburg Gate